CORHC-0005 — Erica Koelder Oral History, April 30, 2010

Erica Koelder
00:03
I'm sorry, when your job is to be the Supreme NATO Allied commander, you have to be doing something right. Did a good job. Yes, he did. He did a wonderful job. And then he kind of, you know, took a demotion and became the president. You know, some people see it as a promotion.

Andrew Woods
00:21
Uh I was a step down.

Erica Koelder
00:22
Is the okay, Mr. President or Supreme NATO Allied Commander? Supreme NATO Allied Commander is a war. Yes, exactly. Like I'm sorry, that's a way cooler.

Andrew Woods
00:36
Commander in chief than cutters.

Erica Koelder
00:38
Not after you've been what he was with NATO.

Andrew Woods
00:44
I remember seeing him in 1960 at a whistle stop in Wheaton, Illinois.

Carrie Gabaree (Gutierrez)
00:52
Oh really? No kidding.

Andrew Woods
00:54
A couple years ago his uh His son was here for a conference.

Erica Koelder
01:00
I love it.

Andrew Woods
01:00

And and I talked to him about it. He says, yeah, I was on that train Oh really?

Erica Koelder
01:05
Very cool. Um his library is in his hometown of Abilene, Kansas, which is about twenty-five minutes from Fort Riley. So and it's beautiful.

01:16
Is it really it is so beautiful. They've got um they've got the museum. is one building, the library is another.

01:25
They have his childhood home where him and all the rest of the boys grew up is still standing. They were able to preserve it and have everything. And you can go in and look.

Carrie Gabaree (Gutierrez)
01:34
Is that all in the same grounds?

Erica Koelder
01:35
All in the same. They built everything around the childhood home. Nice.

Andrew Woods
01:38
And then um we're always used to cut the feet guy that cut the pie.

Erica Koelder
01:42
Mm-hmm. Yep. And then him and Mamie and their child that died in at an early age, there all three are buried at the mausoleum there as well.

01:54
So I mean it's all it's right there and then there's a thirteen foot statue on there. Oh really? It's very big and Is it nicely done?

02:02
It is, but it's a little creepy 'cause it's thirteen feet tall. Like that's big. Very big.

02:08
And you know, whatever. I'm flexible. Whatever.

02:12
If you're gonna have a 13 foot statue, I guess I'll be there and look at it. Because I'm here. Whatever.

02:17
Mm. Do they have gardens there too and everything? Yep.

02:21
And ever like everything in Abilene, you know Talks about Eisenhower and Mamie and their family and how everything all came to be and there's tons of gardens and fountains and little festivals and little readings and They had one exhibit there probably about six or seven months ago and it was the presidential history of baseball. Oh really? And so in all obviously predominantly about him and how baseball fit into his life.

02:54
But it was a lot of the president's and how baseball fit into the presidency and how they're so intertwined and how they, you know, it's customary for the president to be a part of baseball more than it is of any other sport that we have at any other sporting event and Mm-hmm. All these other things and I'm a super geek and so I'm sitting there like reading everything and taking pictures of everything and yeah. It's not the all American sport

Carrie Gabaree (Gutierrez)
03:21
No, I love it.

Erica Koelder
03:22
I love baseball. Me too. I love it.

03:25
I can't wait to bring my husband. I know, it's so important. And you know, and it becomes such an important part of American history like when um When Bush threw out the first pitch at Yankee Stadium after nine eleven, what it and I mean you remember and all I have to do is say those words and all three of us have a different image, but we all remember him walking out there, you know, just so it it was such a much bigger moment than just the president throwing out the first pitch.

03:59
I mean it had all of these things and huge significance. Exactly, you know and it if it the way of life was Exactly. You know, and if he would have done the coin toss at the Super Bowl that season, that's great.

04:11
Wonderful. So happy that you're here, Mr. President. But it doesn't mean.

04:17
It you know, in the in the scheme of history it doesn't mean what throwing out a first pitch does and how it you know and just how it becomes See, I told you I could talk forever. It's a good

thing when it comes to an oral history. Oh yeah.

Andrew Woods
04:32
I'm gonna probably put a little note in front of you every so often. Okay. have a time on it.

04:37
Okay. We'll have like an hour. What that we've completed an hour already?

04:42
We've got through one hour. Okay. One hour and fifteen.

04:44
Uh-huh. Yeah. Probably want to go about two, right?

Carrie Gabaree (Gutierrez)
04:48
Uh yeah, I think we're looking above I mean it doesn't matter how long we go, but we're if I talk for more than two hours, then we are in trouble.

Erica Koelder
04:56
Okay We are all in a world of trouble. Oh, okay. All right. As long as we don't go more than three hours, then we're good.

Carrie Gabaree (Gutierrez)
05:04
So we can just go ahead and get started. You can get started. All right.

05:09
This is Carrie Gutierrez, Assistant Curator of Collections with Erica Colder. It's Friday, April 30th, 2010, and we are at the First Division Museum at Cantini. And I'm just going to jump into my first question with you, Eric.

05:23
Wonderful. What is your husband's name, rank, and role in the Army?

Erica Koelder
05:29
My husband is Sergeant Promotable Thomas Colder. He is a member of 5-4 Cavalry, 2nd Heavy Brigade, 1st Infantry Division, Fort Riley, Kansas. And he at the truest heart of his job, he is a cavalry scout.

Carrie Gabaree (Gutierrez)
05:44
Okay.

Erica Koelder
05:45
How long has he been in the Army?

Carrie Gabaree (Gutierrez)
05:47
Seven years. Has he been in the military as long as you've known him longer?

Erica Koelder
05:54
We have only known each other for Four and a half years. Okay. So he was in the military for about three years before I ever, two or three years about before I ever got into the picture.

06:07
Okay. He'd already completed a deployment. He was already at his first duty station, was very settling into his army life.

06:17
And then we met and chaos has reigned since

Carrie Gabaree (Gutierrez)
06:20
Tell me about um your meeting with him and you know how his being in the military already affected you and then the progress of your relationship.

Erica Koelder
06:31
Um him and I met. He was stationed in Germany at a duty station called Budigan. And he came back to the States on emergency leave and was staying with a friend of his I was a friend of that friend and we met one night and I thought that was the end of it.

06:48
I was very wrong. Um and the night that I met him he was dressed in his class A's Or as he likes to call it his pickle suit 'cause they're the all green, the green shirt, the green jacket, the green pants, everything And so I knew from the second that I met him that he was in the service. I didn't know it was the army, because I have no real military background in my family.

07:14
And you know, as we were talking, oh, I'm in the military, this is what I do, that's great, why are you telling me this? Um but he had a plan and he knew what he wanted to do and he knew he wanted to be career army and so I've known that from the moment I met him and I met him in December and he flew me to Germany to go and just hang out with him three and a half months later. Wow.

07:42

And I flew to Germany after having only met the boy one night. And Got my passport and got on a plane and said, well what the heck am I doing? But I went and came back from my trip to Germany and said, all right, I better figure this army thing out because looks like I'm marrying into it.

08:05
And we dated for a year and a year to the day that I was in Germany we got married Wow. And so I've th you know, from the moment I met him and throughout our entire dating relationship is always been dependent on the army and trying to figure out how we're gonna make our f our relationship work within the confines of the army and And who my husband wanted to be, you know, career military. Am I ready to give up everything that I thought I wanted to do?

08:33
to go and be with him and figure out what I'm supposed to do when I'm moving every two, three, four years and you know, moving to places that I never thought I was gonna live, meeting people I've never thought I was gonna meet. Like am I ready to really just jump in feet first and have at it? And apparently I said yes, and here we are, you know, almost three and a half years later, and best decision I ever made.

Carrie Gabaree (Gutierrez)
08:59
Wonderful. Wonderful. So when you when you first started dating him and you kind of realized that that might be the track that you your life was going on Um, you know, did you really feel like you kind of understood the culture that you were jumping into? Or he just helped you with that as you went along or

Erica Koelder
09:20
It was interesting. My husband, you know, never thought he was going to get married. He swore up and down he would be the crusty old man sitting on a porch.

09:30
talking to young soldiers, when I was your age, this is how the army was. That's how he thought his life was gonna turn out. So he didn't really know how to help me figure out the Army lifestyle and the Army family.

09:46
Okay. But I'm very fortunate that he knew enough To recognize that he knew nothing and he reached out to other soldiers and other army families to help me get acclimated and to help me have somebody to ask the right questions to and get the answers that I needed and help me figure out dress codes and protocol and what to get involved with and what to do and what to do with my spare time and the best way to pack boxes when you move and all these other things and as an engagement gift he got me the Army Wife Handbook. Mm-hmm.

10:22
And that was what I got. And he said, Read this. Everybody says it will be helpful.

10:29
Okay. And I read it cover to cover and it has. It's been very helpful.

10:33
And I started to figure out what I needed to do to get into the army and be a part of the army family and just get on board. And By doing so, we've as a family have grown and found our way as an army family to navigate through just being a part of it because it's a crazy and chaotic challenging but wonderful life if you can just recognize what your part and what your role is. Okay.

11:08
So

Carrie Gabaree (Gutierrez)
11:09
We'll get back to that particular point later. Okay. But I want to move on to the next question for now, but we'll definitely return to that.

11:17
Okay. Um so you are a military wife, but you're also a family readiness support assistant, also um an FRSA. Yes, ma'am.

11:26
What does that mean? How long have you been doing it? And please give me some specific examples of your work, perhaps even a story or two.

Erica Koelder
11:34
Oh gosh. I don't know if there's enough time on the tape to tell you about stories. Um the FRSA position in general was just created within the last probably five or so years and it was driven by the fact that the army began to recognize how important taking care of the family was and they had volunteers up until that point doing what I am a paid civilian staffer of the United States Army to do.

12:07
And it's the housekeeping, it's maintaining your rosters. making sure you know how to get a hold of family members, having a pool of resources about your specific duty station that you can provide to new family members or family members in crisis. and being an administrative assistant to your battalion or brigade commander in all things related to family And so with the position as it is, it gives that battalion or brigade commander a lot of latitude.

12:41

to how your role is gonna work. And there are some FRSAs that they go in in the morning. They do their actual true administrative assistant details, their housekeeping, you know, maintaining rosters, maintaining spreadsheets, Word documents, PowerPoint presentations.

13:00
And that's pretty much the extent of their day. There's other FRSAs that do that as well as assist the battalion commander in planning, you know, battalion level events, helping the company commanders and the company first sergeants get with their families. How do you reach out to your families the best?

13:19
And really embedding themselves in that unit to make everybody else's job a little bit easier. I'm kind of in that side. My battalion commander gives me a ton of latitude.

13:32
To step in and work with his staff and his command group to assist the volunteers for the family readiness groups or the FRGs and assist the family members in the battalion and in these companies to make positive, safe, healthy decisions. as we get ready to lead up to a deployment during the actual 12 to 18 months of a deployment. And then when everybody comes home and everybody's all excited But your soldier's been gone and there is a change and there is some adjustment.

14:05
It's making sure that I help him, help his command and staff make help the families make good decisions.

Carrie Gabaree (Gutierrez)
14:12
So I don't know, um, can you even get more specific? Maybe telling me about a particular family that you've helped or a particular soldier or parti you know, wife, child, anything like that? Um If you're allowed to.

Erica Koelder
14:27
Yeah, I at a high level, absolutely. I had just started in the position, only been there probably about two months, and was Down in one of the company areas, just hanging out with soldiers, getting to know them. you know, talking to them, talking to the leadership, seeing where I kind of wanted to go and what I needed to do to help them.

14:56
And a soldier comes up to me after hearing me talk about what I do and what my office is supposed to do. And he kind of pulled me aside and said Ma'am, I think I need your help. Okay, what can I help you with?

15:12
What do you what do you need? And he told me about his wife who you know, was going through a high-risk pregnancy and they didn't know how to get her the help they needed. And You know, he didn't know who to ask and who to talk to.

15:29
He was very new to Fort Riley and apparently he felt that I could help him and he was like Well maybe she'll know and I was able to help get them with TRICARE and get them with the hospital and get them with the um ACS, which is Army Community Service, Exceptional Family Member Program. so that they could have the resources available to them to get to the right doctors and make that, you know, a healthy baby and When I talked to him, his wife was approximately three months along. Six months after that, healthy baby.

16:05
And wife is, you know, delivered a healthy baby. She was fine. Everything turned out great.

16:12
Okay. So good. I was kind of excited.

16:14
Yeah.

Carrie Gabaree (Gutierrez)
16:15
So um what are some of the more chal are there any um like really challenging stories or difficult situations that you can tell me about? Um

Erica Koelder
16:27
Currently, as of this moment in time, all 600 plus of my soldiers are deployed. And deployments can bring out the best in families and they can bring out the worst in families. And We have a company that was stood up simply to support the families in the rear and on the home front.

16:52
And so those are the only soldiers that I have that I work for that are truly back at Fort Riley. and every day it's a new challenge, whether it's you know, a wife is so upset and distressed and distraught or whatever it is that she can't remember to have groceries in the cupboard to have food on the table or, you know, her soldier was the one that took care of paying the rent if they lived off post and in the chaos of him walking out the door She forgot how to ask, you know, how did you do it? Because we never had a problem before and now we have a problem.

17:34
Or You know, my husband came home on R and R and you know, we got pregnant and I don't know what to do, you know. Because he's not here, he can't ask his chain of command, I I'm

kind of at a loss. What am I supposed to do?

Speaker 4
17:47
Mm-hmm

Erica Koelder
17:48
And every day between myself, the commander, the first sergeant, and then the five platoon sergeants. It's what we just pick up where the soldier and that chain of command left off. Helping these families work through problems, getting them the help they need, getting them the resources that they need.

18:11
And then every once in a while we get lucky and we have a family that you know, something amazing happens that, you know, a wife is given an award at work or if it's a dual military family, the spouse that's back home is being promoted and we will all go to the promotion ceremony because the soldier can't be there and it's you know, just kind of stepping in and doing what we can to make everybody just get through those 12 to 18 months, however long the deployment is. Currently First Engineer Battalion, which is the battalion that I work for. They're currently slotted for twelve months.

18:48
But it's the Army, it could change. Um, you know, and our job is just to make sure that we have twelve months of happy, healthy families and then we bring home, you know, six hundred plus healthy, happy soldiers and then we reunite them and help them become a family again. And that's what we get to do.

Carrie Gabaree (Gutierrez)
19:07
How how hands-on do you get in terms of like for the exam example of help, you know, the wife needed help paying the rent? Um would that be you who steps in and are you just you find someone? Okay, yep.

Erica Koelder
19:21
So there's a lot of coordination. A lot of my job is information and resource gathering and then pushing it back out. I'm not a decision the FRSA position is not a decision maker.

19:34
It is not an influencer. it is predominantly looked at and used as an administrative position and a coordination position. But in order to do the job successfully you've gotta know what your resources, you've gotta know who's gonna be able to help that wife the best of their ability and make it a positive situation instead of making the situation worse.

19:57
You have to know the resources around the post that you're at. to make sure that you're talking to the right people and so that you know a potentially very distressful situation can still end up, you know, with a positive thought, you know, hey, they really helped me out. They didn't steer me wrong.

20:16
It's gonna be okay. And so I help m a lot of the soldiers in the rear detachment element, which is our Delta company, I help them and guide them to the right resources for the right people and the right families.

Carrie Gabaree (Gutierrez)
20:32
Okay When you were new to the job, how long did it take you to come up to speed on some of that information? 'Cause I would I would imagine that when you're new to the job and you have, you know, a lot of people knocking on your door, um, that would be something that would be very difficult. If you can speak a little bit about that.

Erica Koelder
20:49
I have been with the Die Hard Battalion for 16 months and I am still learning new things. So it doesn't matter how long you're in the position, you'll always learn new things because with the Army lifestyle people are always changing and in and out and processes change and procedures change and forms change and requirements change. So even if I walked in knowing everything, six month sixteen months is a long time.

21:15
It's gonna have changed at some point. So I learn every day new things and I knew when I first started I knew enough to know that I didn't know everything. And so I found other FRSAs within the Fort Riley community that had been in their position longer than I had.

21:35
to kind of just get me started and get me moving in the right direction. And I s but even with that information I still went out, met with people. I explained who I was, who I worked for, and asked them to still teach me and get on board with them.

21:51
So it wasn't just, well, Suzy Q told me this is what it's supposed to be. you know, and with my position on behalf of my commander, I went the extra step to make sure that I was the one that knew all of the procedures, knew who to talk to, so that I was helping the situation instead of just, oh, this is who you go talk to. No, you talk to, you know, this is the person in this room at this office, here's their phone number.

22:17

Because n doing those just name, phone number and a building number instead of this is who you talk to puts family members more at ease. It's oh She knows what she's talking about. Right.

22:29
She is confident in giving me this information. It's you know, she's okay with it. And she you know, she's confident in giving this to me.

22:36
It must be the right information and hopefully if it doesn't work out then I'll go back to her. You know, if that wasn't the right thing and we got it wrong, then let's try again. But I trust her on behalf of these commanders and these first sergeants um to help make the right decisions and that's a huge part of my job.

22:55
Is having the faith of my command group and my staff elements that they trust me enough to do the right thing, both for the families as well as the soldiers, because they go hand in hand. Do right for the families, you do right for the soldiers. Do right for the soldiers, you've done right for the families.

23:11
They worked so closely together.

Carrie Gabaree (Gutierrez)
23:14
Now in your job it it's it sounds interesting because from everything that you're saying, I mean i I mean a lot of it is coordination, um but obviously you have to build a rapport with these people so that they trust you. Um so there is a relationship that's built um you know as part of the job from what you're saying. Your job is not, from what I'm hearing, it is not counselor or or therapist or any or anything like that.

23:39
But It sounds like that could easily come into the mix in in in handling situations in dealing with people. How do you balance that and you know how do you see that? Does that come up a lot with families and people?

Erica Koelder
23:54
How do you work with that? Um, it does come up a lot, especially when there is, you know, an immediate crisis type situation. And the best that I can do is just be there with that family and then as soon as it's possible get the right people involved that are the counselors, that are the therapists that are the right people to make decisions, knowing who those people are and being able to pull them out of the back of my pocket at a moment's notice to get them on board.

24:29
So that not only am I able to, you know, stay as a neutral party and stay, you know, as just a resource. But also again it by bringing somebody in and knowing who that right person is and bringing them in very quickly, again, it builds a trust with that family or with that soldier that Okay, she brought in the right person, er you know, this is what needs to happen, this is who I needed to talk to. And so it's knowing, but yeah, there's You know, people will come into my office and you know, they don't know who else to talk to.

25:03
And so then they tell me a lot of details that I probably don't need to know. But comes with the territory and you know I'm glad that they feel that my office and my position is a place that they can come. and get the resources that they need.

25:20
I work very closely with the company level family readiness group, leadership, volunteers. Those are all volunteer positions. And work very, very closely with those women.

25:33
Um they come into my office, you know, and they use me as a resource. You know, Erica, this is what we want to see happen at our next FRG meeting. Okay, I'll make that happen.

25:46
And they know that as long as they give me the list, it's gonna happen. You know, so I mean it's it's not always, you know, crisis, crisis, crisis. I mean it's i there is a lot of my job as well on the coordination side of the house that does involve Air cud, this is what I want to see in my end state.

26:05
Please make this happen. Okay. Done.

Carrie Gabaree (Gutierrez)
26:09
Okay. So So you're you're aware of kind of the boundaries, I mean very much so. And you're it sounds like you're very careful in staying true to them.

Erica Koelder
26:18
I try so hard because if I didn't I probably would have been burnt out of my job already. For one. And for two, by knowing what my boundaries are, it again allows me to build that rapport with my commanders, with my staff, with my non-commissioned officer leadership.

26:38
That they know that I'm not going to get involved. They can use me as a resource get what they need from my office in my capacity, but that I'm not going to, you know, say, well Hey First

Sergeant, your so-and-so needs this help and they have to do this and this is what I think. I'll go to First Sergeant and say, First Sergeant, Here's what happened, here's the resources that I have from my office.

27:06
Have at it. Okay. Okay.

27:09
And by being able to keep that, it then allows again for them to trust me and come back and say, okay. It's one less person that's involved. Because with army, you tend to get a lot of people involved in dramatic situations and it just makes them that much worse.

Carrie Gabaree (Gutierrez)
27:25
Yeah.

Erica Koelder
27:26
And so it's one less person in the middle of the frecas and so, yeah. Okay.

Carrie Gabaree (Gutierrez)
27:35
Tell me about being both the wife of an active duty soldier and a family readiness support assistant. How does one affect the other? Oh gosh.

Erica Koelder
27:47
They go so hand in hand that I don't know how someone who is not a military spouse does my job. because I work for military families, I work for military spouses, and we are a very special and unique group. And if you're not one of us It's hard to understand completely what we're going through.

28:11
And I don't mean that in any way like, oh, you're not one of the club. It's not that way But it is a very unique lifestyle. It is a very there are many, many challenges that we go through that civilians we can tell you until we're blue in the face, but until you are actually married to the army.

28:31
you won't really understand. And um because I work so closely with my soldiers and with my families, I think it helps to be a military wife 'cause I can honestly go up there and talk to them and say, hey Been there, done that, got the t-shirt. Here's what my experience was.

28:49
It was a great experience. It was a not so great experience. When it's not so great, I have the

capacity to help my commander make it better for you.

29:00
And so it they absolutely go hand in hand. And then to turn around and when I go home at night, my husband and I are able to talk about more than oh th it was nice today, it was sunny and I had a good day and oh I had a good day too and you know, we're actually able to talk about things that are going on because we are both in the army environment. He is an active duty soldier and me being as close to being in the army as I can short of wearing ACUs or wearing a uniform every day.

29:39
You know, and so it has been very helpful when it comes to planning and calendars and deployments makes it a little bit tricky. But, you know, it's the army. So you figure it out and hopefully you have the right leadership in both sides, you know, his leadership as well as my leadership that will allow for us to be able to be a part of one another's army life.

30:06
You know, him being able to attend events with my battalion and my families Me being able to go and attend events with his soldiers and with his families. And we've been very fortunate so far that both leaders have allowed that to happen as much as they have been able to. So, you know, and then that way too my soldiers can see, oh, she you know, first of all she does have a life outside the office and that also, yeah, you know, she's able to make you know, block leaves and four day weekends and schools and, you know, T D wise, which is when you go to a temporary duty location for a couple of weeks or a couple months.

30:53
Well, she's able to make those happen. She's gone through a deployment. She did she you know, she did okay.

30:59
You know, she didn't get put into a hospital. I mean she I mean she she did all right. She made it through and she did well and she came out the other side just fine and Well, okay, so she she probably knows what she's talking about.

31:12
Maybe I can do it too. You know, maybe I can ask her the questions, you know, when it's You know, the night before and I couldn't sleep because all I did was miss my husband. You know, is is that normal?

31:23
And she's actually gonna understand and she's gonna get it. You know, so it my husband and I laugh because being an FRSA is right now is we're still sort of newlyweds. It's been one of the best things for our marriage because I do understand and I have a new appreciation for him

when he says, I have to work late because something's going on with one of my soldiers or we have a late meeting or we have this and it's I understand more because I am able to see the day-to-day events of a unit more so than a lot of army wives.

31:59
And so it's forced me to have a little bit more patience when I get the phone call that says I'm gonna be late for dinner, just leave a plate in the microwave for me or we're gonna have dinner late or you know, plans changing at the last minute.

Speaker 4
32:14
Mm-hmm.

Erica Koelder
32:15
So it's been helpful.

Carrie Gabaree (Gutierrez)
32:19
How do you deal with the challenges of being both the wife of an active duty soldier and an FRSA?

Erica Koelder
32:28
Lots of patience. Um probably more tears than I should because You know, it does get frustrating and it does get upsetting when I have to pick between my job and my family because I love my job. I love being able to go into work in the morning and say I work for the Die Hard Battalion.

32:50
I get to spend my day making soldiers and families' lives easier or doing something that's gonna make somebody else's life easier as a volunteer. But then when doing that affects my ability to maybe go to a picnic with my husband and his squadron. It's like, well, okay, is it really worth it to be involved and be here and doing this?

33:16
Like where do I really where do I need to be? And I can't be two places at once. And so it's just it's trying desperately to find that balance and looking to my leadership as well as his.

33:29
you know, where do you want us as a family to be? What is more important? You know, my husband came home and approximately a month later we had the deployment ceremony for my soldiers.

33:43

And, you know, we struggled, you know, is my husband gonna be able to get the time off? Because they're just starting to get back into the swing of being home. You know, is he gonna be able to be there and watch me farewell my soldiers?

33:59
And we talked to both leaders and they said, you know what? This is bigger than being at the office for an hour Sergeant Colder, you need to be there with your wife and you need to be there for that. And, you know, we look to other Army families.

34:15
That we have met along the way in our three and a half years as a family that have been in the army much longer than we have. that you know we go to them and say, hey, what you know, how do you guys do it? You've been married 15, 20 some years.

34:32
You're happy as I've ever seen anybody that's been married that long And to be married that long in the army is a huge deal. You know, how do you do it? What are we supposed to do?

34:43
You know, we we don't know. We don't know all the answers. You know, and it's him and I individually, you know, when we're at home and we're not at his office, we're not at my office.

34:54
It's just, you know, him and I together making that decision what is right for our family and I'm very fortunate that he and I work really well together and we are able to say, okay, this is the decision that we have to make. It might not be the right one looking back, but it's the decision that we're making and it's the one that we're gonna live with, so be it. You know, and we've been able to do it and so far we've done pretty well with those decisions.

Carrie Gabaree (Gutierrez)
35:26
Was Fort Pardon me, was Fort Riley the first military base home that you had in the Army or for both of you? And tell me about coming there and getting acclimatic.

Erica Koelder
35:37
Uh Fort Riley was my second duty station. It was my husband's third. He was stationed in Germany at Boudigan, like I said, when we first met.

35:50
And then in the spring of 2006 he PCS'd or permanent change of station move, however you want to look at it He PCS back to the States and was assigned to the National Training Center at Fort Irwin, California. And after we got married, that's where I moved. And so National Training Center at Fort Orwell was my first duty station.

36:17
And in the Army. People either love or hate Fort Irwin. It is in the middle of the Mojave Desert.

36:27
It is 40 miles off Interstate 15. And it is in the middle of nowhere. And it takes a very special person to appreciate being there.

36:44
And I knew that's where I was gonna be going after we got married. So I said Okay, I'll pack my stuff and I'll drink a lot of water and a lot of Gatorades so that when it's 120 degrees I don't fall over in the middle of the street and But at the end of the day, it was a great place for us. I was in a great position and a great job.

37:05
I worked for Army Community Service. Four days a week supporting soldiers, because I've supported soldiers and their families since I married into the Army. It's kind of my new passion in life, I guess.

37:19
Um, I only worked four days a week and when my husband would have four day weekends, my boss would say, you know what, why don't you work a couple extra hours Monday, Tuesday, Wednesday Take a half day with your husband Thursday since you guys just got married a couple months ago and go, you know, either just hang out at your home or go somewhere. 'Cause we were two hours from Vegas, two hours from Orange County in the beach, and three and a half hours from San Diego. And I think it was like five or six hours, maybe a little bit more, up to Sonoma and Napa and up into Wine Country.

37:56
So we did and we didn't have a dog. We had you know we have no children currently. We've added a dog since we got to Kansas, but you know, out there we didn't have one and so we would flip a coin.

38:08
Are we going to Vegas or are we going to the beach this week? weekend. You know, and to be able to be newly married and just be able to pick up and go to Vegas or pick up and go to Orange County and go to the beach.

38:19
It's pretty fun. And, you know, I was only out there for a year, so I didn't have time to not like it. The newness and the excitement of being able to go different places never really wore off.

38:33
Um from the National Training Center we then came down on orders to come to Fort Riley, which is where we're currently stationed And we arrived at Fort Riley in August of 2008, and my

husband walked out the door about 45 days later to support OIF. Which was an interesting interesting way of being welcomed to Fort Riley. But it is what it is.

39:00
I mean it's the army. You roll with it and if you don't you're gonna get swallowed up and hate it and then you're gonna fight with your husband and he'll fight with you and it's not worth it. At the end of the day it's not worth arguing because he wasn't getting out of that deployment.

39:15
The army said This is what your army destiny is and this is where you're going and you're gonna go and you're gonna be gone twelve months and you're leaving your family and she'll figure it out.

Carrie Gabaree (Gutierrez)
39:29
So when you I imagine having been at Fort Irwin really helped you, you know, get acclimated almost by yourself, you know, to a large extent at Fort Riley. Absolutely Absolutely. Um, did that I mean did that experience at Fort Irwin I mean just kind of you you felt okay at Fort Riley? I mean what specia s what special things did you how did you deal with that by yourself? Was there anything special that you did or you you felt okay with it or

Erica Koelder
39:54
After I got over the shock of okay, he's leaving, holy crap, what are we gonna do? Yeah. Because we didn't have a house, we didn't have any of our stuff, our stuff was still all in storage.

40:07
you know, I didn't have a job m you know, I mean we had no clue that that was coming down the pipe But again at Fort Irwin we found a lot of families that helped us and guided us and one of the activities that I got involved with at Fort Irwin is called Army Family Team Building or AFTB And I loved it. It was a great program. It helped me learn about the Army.

40:33
Program is approximately fifteen years fourteen or fifteen years old now. And what it does, it starts off in level one and it is just a basic general, welcome to the Army. And they teach you about acronyms, they teach you about the chain of command.

40:47
They teach you about, you know, the different programs that are available to Army families and Army children if you have children. It teaches you, you know, some basic, basic protocol, things like that. Things that you need to know just enough to get by.

41:06

Level two, it takes those and gets a little bit more in depth Level three, even more in depth. And then if you choose, after you've done those three, you can actually go back and be an instructor. So that you're the one teaching the new army families or the new army volunteers or the new army civilians Kind of how things work around the Army and you're able to help share your experiences, learn from the people that you're teaching, as well as continue to make sure that your skills are sharp and what you know about the Army is sharp And I became a certified instructor.

41:43
And when we got to Fort Riley, I was like, you know what? I I better start meeting some people and I better start figuring this out. So I'll just go to the AFTB program manager and I'll sign up to start teaching some classes.

41:59
And I did Because Army Family Team Building is at every installation in the world. Everybody has it. Because you don't know where your first duty station is gonna be.

42:13
Germany or you could be stationed, you know, in Georgia. I mean it doesn't matter. So they have it everywhere.

42:20
And it's something that you can do at every duty station. if you so choose. And for me it was great 'cause that's how I started getting out and meeting people and kind of digging into the community and figuring out what this Fort Riley place was all about because it's so much bigger than Fort Erwin Fort Irwin is like this.

42:39
Fort Riley is like this. So, you know, I'd never been around a place that had multiple brigades and tons of people and grass. I'd never seen an army installation that had grass because Fort Irwin in the desert, there's nothing.

Carrie Gabaree (Gutierrez)
42:55
Yeah.

Erica Koelder
42:55
Like The commanding general of post has a tiny tiny yard and I think a couple of the brigade commanders out there had a tiny tiny yard. Nobody else. Everybody else has dirt.

43:09
You know, so to be able to go and drive and to from one end of Fort Riley to the other can take a good forty-five minutes. Maybe a little bit longer. At Fort Irwin, ten minutes from one end to

the other.

43:24
So to just be able to go and have somebody and figure out a way that I could meet people to show me the difference between Fort Riley and Fort Irwin. It was great. And so I did and I met people and actually through the Army Family team building volunteers that I was working with and teaching and doing instructor modules with, that's actually how um the opportunity to become an FRSA with the First Engineer Battalion was brought about.

43:53
Okay. Was through meeting people who knew people, who knew people that knew this position was gonna be opening and, you know Good army families will learn how valuable networking can be. Because by networking, first of all, all you have to do is say, hey, we're going to you know Fort Stewart next.

44:17
You'll have friends say, Oh, I was at Fort Stewart from so and so. I know someone that's still stationed there. Get in touch with this person and you by knowing a lot of people and getting involved and having different things in your army family background will allow you to get to a different place where you have no clue what you're doing Or you find out that your husband's walking out the door in 45 days and it helps you kind of just dig in.

44:44
Because like I said, you don't have a choice. The army doesn't. You know, bless the bless its heart. The army doesn't care that your husband's leaving in forty-five days.

44:51
Right. The army needs your husband. And you just have to figure it out.

44:57
So

Carrie Gabaree (Gutierrez)
45:01
Speaking to that, tell me about your experience from the moment that you found out. that he was going to be deployed. I mean from that first deployment in that first deployment to the time after he got back. Tell me about that experience in in your shoes from your perspective.

Erica Koelder
45:19
Oh gosh. I didn't even really have time to think and get ready for him being gone and to, you know, mentally prepare for him. leaving because it was so quick and it was like, okay, we have to get our documents in order, we've gotta do this, we've gotta do this, you know, and it was making that list and just trying desperately while trying to find a house and get settled and do

all these other things to check off the blocks and make sure that he's walking out the door successful.

45:48

And You know, and that was overwhelming and scary, and I had no idea what I was doing. But I got him out the door and with my huge list of things that were still in our household goods that I had to find a box big enough so that I could send to him over in Iraq. But um You know, it just I didn't even really have time to think about it until he was actually on the plane and I went home and I'm gonna start crying probably Probably.

46:20

And I was by myself and I was like, holy crap. So this is what it feels like. This is what everybody's stories were like.

46:30

This is what it feels like. Oh, I don't think I like this very much. And I didn't. I was very mad when he first walked out the door because It's just I love my husband.

46:45

Right. Of course I'm gonna be mad. And it's okay to be mad.

46:49

I had to figure that out later. Like I got I started getting mad at myself that I was still upset. I was like, wait a minute.

46:55

This is stupid. I'm allowed to be upset. You know, again, I like him.

47:00

I like having my best friend with me doing things. It's kinda nice. That's kinda why I married him.

47:09

You know, not everybody gets to marry their best friend, and I'm very fortunate that I did. And so then once I figured out, okay, it's alright to be angry Now what the heck are you gonna do for the next 12 months? Because this isn't changing and he's not coming home.

47:29

Okay. Keep busy. And so that's what I did.

47:33

The first three months that he was gone, I was traveling and visiting friends almost two of those three months. Wow, in total. I would leave on a Thursday, throw our new puppy in the back of my car, and I would go visit my friends or I would go home to see my mom or I'd just go somewhere.

47:58
'Cause I kinda didn't really want to be home. I was like, well if I'm home then I'm gonna sit and I'm gonna wallow and then I'm gonna cry and then I'm gonna get mad and that defeats the whole purpose And so my dog learned to travel and he learned to ride in the car and love it. And um Now I can't get him out of the car once he's in the car because he thinks we're going on an adventure.

48:22
And you know, that was, you know, just a true that was my coping mechanism For some people, it is volunteering with their kids at school, some people it's volunteering in other areas of the community, some people it's getting a job. For me, that initial gut coping mechanism was just getting out of there and traveling and being with my friends. And then once that got a little bit old That's when I got my job and that's when I became the FRSA for the First Engineer Battalion.

48:54
And um I've been with them since January of 2009

Carrie Gabaree (Gutierrez)
48:59
Okay.

Erica Koelder
49:00
So and then because I had that, that became my new coping mechanism and my new focus. And I was able to Underst in being a part of the battalion and being able to start understanding and asking questions about the army. to a bunch of people and to a bunch of soldiers that have been deployed.

49:22
Well what's my husband going through? What's it like? And then meeting their wives saying, you know, what was it like for you And then between his unit and the unit that I worked for, I was able to start taking better care of myself and you know, just growing and turning the deployment into a positive thing.

49:42
And it, you know, then I when I he came home twelve months later I I just sat back and said, holy crap, we did it. And you're coming home just like I put you out the door. Thankfully my husband was not hurt.

50:03
I, you know, was able to go pick him up and I was happy and joyous and you know I was so excited to be bringing him home because I had this new job and our dog had grown up and he wasn't, you know, this big anymore and he was gonna be able to be a part of the life that I had

started to build at Fort Riley. You know, 'cause he wasn't really a part of anything 'cause he was gone so quickly and so I was able to bring him into the Fort Riley lifestyle that I had built and what I wanted for our family. And he got on board and said, this is great.

50:36
Let's have at it. And I remember sitting in the redeployment Welcome Home Center building, just waiting. And it was probably the longest four hours of my life.

50:50
Because all I wanted to do was just see my husband come out and then hug him and take him home. And it was, oh, it was so long just waiting and waiting. And then when I saw the first soldiers walking out, I was so excited.

51:06
and I was so focused and excited and nervous and scared and all these things, I completely missed my husband walking out the door. Completely missed him. And then when I realized that I had missed him, I started panicking.

51:19
I'm like, oh my gosh Oh my gosh, I didn't see him! Is he here? Did he make it?

51:24
Holy crap, what am I gonna do? And My friends that were with me, bless their heart, because they they're like, Erica, he's here, it's fine. I'm like, no, I don't see him.

51:36
I can't find him. Erica, there are three hundred soldiers out there and they all look alike right now. So it's okay.

51:43
No, it's not. He's gonna think I don't love him because I didn't see him. And I, you know, when they broke formation and scattered to the winds to go and find their families.

51:56
I didn't see him right away again because he ended up in his in the formation on the complete opposite side of the room from where I was. So I had to wait for him to like wade around all these people and all these families and all these soldiers. And I still remember when I saw his blond and my husband has very, very, very blonde hair.

52:18
Mm-hmm. I was born that way. And I saw this you know six foot tall blonde person walking towards me and I started screaming and like took off and everybody was trying to you know like grab like Erica he'll get here I'm like I don't care I'm going and oh my gosh Just so excited to see him.

52:42
And again, people can tell you what it's like. Not until I'm gonna start crying again. Not until you actually get to Be there holding them knowing that you get to put them in the car and you get to put their stuff in the car and they're coming home with you.

53:02
That is an amazing, amazing feeling. And I'll get to do it again sooner than I care to admit, but Again, that's the army and that's the way that the army does things and you figure it out. Mm-hmm.

Carrie Gabaree (Gutierrez)
53:18
So there wasn't I mean there was just was there when after he, you know, walked in the door home. Was there was it kind of difficult or strange getting him acclimated again or not at all

Erica Koelder
53:31
It was a little difficult because he had no idea where he was living. Okay. And um, you know, because he hadn't been to the house.

53:39
Um that we were living in was we had originally had to live off post and um he hadn't and right before he came home I moved into a house on post So he'd never been to his house. He didn't know where his stuff was. And so he kinda wandered around for half an hour trying to figure out what was going on.

54:00
And then um it was challenging because he came home and then 45 days later, I had to go to that same building where I had picked him up and watch my soldiers walk out the door and say goodbye to their families. Yeah. So, you know, we d never really had a chance to you know, I don't it was an interesting time because I'm trying to bring him home and figure all these things out and I'm trying to put my soldiers out the door and you know make sure that that's a success and that we don't have anybody, you know, just completely falling apart, losing their mind because that's not good and that's not fun and you know, I mean we are still he's been home for seven or eight months now, as of today, and we still every once in a while is like Are you sure you like are you sure that you know what it's like to live with your wife and, you know, live with another person?

55:02
Because I can assure you that that's not normal. Yeah. And the same thing can be said for me.

55:06
I was like, wait a minute, I am so used to not living with a boy that Oh my gosh, there's a boy living in my house. Crap. And we still have those moments.

55:18
And you have them and that's just but that's normal and that's healthy because you were separated. So okay.

Carrie Gabaree (Gutierrez)
55:27
What was the nature of communication during his first deployment and then subsequent deployments and how do you deal with that?

Erica Koelder
55:34
Um with him. Oh, thanks. Sure.

55:38
Um with his deployment, where they were stationed at, internet was very tricky. Internet was, you know, not always easy, not always available. So I got maybe an email or two a week, you know, after he'd waited in line and got his computer time and I got a phone call probably every seven to ten days.

Carrie Gabaree (Gutierrez)
56:03
Okay.

Erica Koelder
56:04
And me, being the super geek that I am, would get so excited when I get that phone call I'd make a big heart in my day planner when I had gotten a phone call from him. And so I could look back and see this is how many times I got to talk to my husband and I sat down and I looked at it and I'm like, oh my god, that's how many times I talked to my husband in a year. Mm-hmm.

56:26
Because it was Fifty times. I talked to him on the phone that he was gone. Wow.

56:32
Now again, that seems like a lot, but when you break it down and they're gone for 52 weeks. Yeah. It was just over a week in between our phone calls.

56:42
Right. And those phone calls were never long enough. About how long?

56:49
average was probably about fifteen to twenty minutes. Now you have to cram in a week's worth of information into twenty minutes and you know he can't really talk about what he's doing because they're unsecured phone lines so he can't say You know, obviously this is not anything

that happened, but he couldn't say, you know, I was out on a mission and this is what we did and this is where we were. He can't tell me those things.

57:13
You know, I can ask. He can't tell me. So, you know, 15-20 minutes of me, this is what I did this week, and this was this, and I got to the point that I would write everything down and I would carry that list with me so that if I was out or wherever I was and I got that phone call, I knew exactly what I wanted to tell him.

57:33
And the other big thing, you know, what Army families have done since the beginning of time, letters and care packages. And because of the remote locations that he was in that was just as much a component of it as that phone call. Now with my soldiers as I'm watching them and watching them talk to their families and interact with their families It's much different.

57:57
Where my soldiers are currently stationed at, they have regular access to internet at a decent You know, I mean it's not great. It's not anything like we have here in the United States, but it's better, you know, it's better than sketchy. You know, so my families and my soldiers have been Skyping a lot.

58:20
Mm-hmm. You know, and they talk about, oh, I Skyped with my husband and I Skyped with my husband, you know, today, I Skyped with him yesterday, I think he's gonna Skype with me tomorrow and you know, they instant message and they email and because of the location they're able to talk. to their husbands and to their wives, because I have both males and female soldiers.

58:40
Um they're able to talk to their families much more than I was. And As the FRSA, I'm so excited because that means that they're staying a part of their family. Their family is able to include that soldier in as much as they can, even though they're at a remote distance.

58:58
But then the army wife part of me is so jealous because they get to talk to their husband and they get to see their husband on Skype when they're talking to him and Oh man, that would have been nice. You know, how it's gonna work in the future, I don't know, because a lot of it just depends on where he is stationed when he is deployed. You know, if he's in a location that has great internet, hopefully we'll Skype.

59:28
But even if it has great internet, odds are good he's gonna be out and he'll be working and be on missions and so I won't be able to talk to him and Then I sit back and think about it and say,

well, you know what? If I get used to talking to him every day and then he doesn't call, what if I panic? And what if our routine has to change because, you know, he's not on mission or there's other things going on, like what am I gonna do?

59:56
What is my gut reaction gonna be? Am I gonna get scared? Am I gonna freak out?

01:00:00
Do I really wanna deal with that? Because it's not fun. It is not a fun experience as an army wife to be waiting by the phone and being scared.

01:00:12
You know, and there was um while my husband was deployed, there was an incident within the camp where he was located, a soldier um had found a weapon and discharged it and had killed um another soldier and a civilian staffer that were over there. And I knew that I knew that location. I knew that was where my husband was and then to have to sit there and wait until I heard from him.

01:00:47
It was n it was not a good feeling at all. And so it's like, well, if he has better communication tools, do I really want to get involved in that? Because even just those couple hours, that was stressful enough Do I want to do that on a continuous basis for 52 plus weeks?

01:01:04
I'm not sure I do. Yeah. You know, so I mean, but again, that's a decision of the family.

01:01:11
And how your family and how your relationship works. But again, like I said, the FRSA, the career part of me, when I see my family is getting to talk and be able to share things, I'm s overjoyed. Because that just makes my job a little bit easier.

01:01:27
Right. And it makes it a little bit nicer because then there's always just a sense of relief after you hang up the phone or you get that email they're like They're okay. Alright.

01:01:45
And you can always tell when an army wife has just gotten a phone call, or an army husband has just gotten a phone call from their soldier. So they have a smile on their face that is so big and you cannot wipe that smile off their face. Even if you tried.

01:02:00
It just is not gonna happen. And it is just it is such a It is just the most amazingly pure smile and feeling ever. Because it's just it's such a gut reaction.

01:02:17

Like I just can't believe I'm excited that I got a phone call. But it's from eight thousand miles away and he's all right. Yeah.

01:02:23

Like it's a very Like I don't know, primal is not the word, but it's a very, you know, gut level reaction. And so

Carrie Gabaree (Gutierrez)

01:02:34

Let me I I've heard about um and I was gonna ask you about you know when when you know that you're gonna maybe get that phone call just over a week. That's kind of what you're expecting or whatever. Or maybe you don't know when you're gonna get the phone call.

01:02:46

phone call. I would think that there's and you sort of address it with, you know, making a list of everything you want to talk about. I would I would think that there's um a certain pressure that goes along with that phone call.

01:03:00

And maybe you can speak. I've I've heard a lot about um it being very difficult for some families or some husbands and wives to have those phone conversations. And maybe it's because of the pressure that goes along with it, but you know, sometimes there can be a lot of anger and sometimes there's arguing and I would imagine that if there if that does take place during the phone call or during the communication, it's that much harder afterwards.

01:03:29

And that can be very stressful on a relationship. Um, you know, so you've just talked a lot about a lot, you know, the joyful side of the experiences, but especially as an FRSA Um, what can you tell me about the other side of that and, you know, maybe some of the stresses that go along with it?

Erica Koelder

01:03:48

It is hard, you know, because if you're only getting ten or fifteen, maybe even twenty minutes, and you have this list, say you run out of time. Say the connection is bad and the connection just cuts off mid-sentence. Or you forget something on your list, or you know, they call on a Saturday morning and then Saturday afternoon this amazing thing happens that you're like, oh, I just want to tell him.

01:04:14

And you can't. And then you're you're like, oh, this totally sucks. Why can't I get a hold of him? And then you s you do get a little bit angry.

01:04:24

And You do get mad and you get upset and you get frustrated and with my husband and I he comes you know he came home and he tells the story to everybody who will listen to him that when we would be on the phone and he would get his n you know, you have two minutes left on this call and, you know, you have a minute, you have thirty seconds, he would get those notifications and he would tell me I would start talking faster. I would start trying to cram in those last minute things and he would feel awful that he had to cut me off. And I was like, I know, I'm just trying to get everything in and I don't want to forget anything and I want you to be a part of everything that's going on back here and You know, he's like, Erica, I couldn't get you to shut up.

01:05:13

And he does. He tells everybody the story of how many times it would take him. And it took him as he says, an average of five times telling me that he had to get off the phone before I would actually shut up, tell him that I loved him and to be safe and that I would talk to him the next time I talked to him.

01:05:29

Mm-hmm And it's probably true because I like to talk to him. But it is and like while it is this overwhelming sense of joy and you're so excited and you heard from him that means he's safe and he's good and he's healthy There is a lot of time that you're just like, I wish I could have had two more minutes. Oh, I wish I could have this.

01:05:52

And especially for me personally The night, like if I got a phone call um in on a Saturday morning, Saturday night was always so hard. Yeah. Because I'm like I just talked to you this morning.

01:06:08

I want to talk to you before I go to bed. Yeah. You know.

01:06:12

I just want to be able to talk to you.

Speaker 4

01:06:14

Mm.

Erica Koelder

01:06:14

So I mean, there are times that it's very hard. And, you know, even my wives now that I work with and I work for, they say, you know, I don't care that I get to see him and I get to talk to him four or five times a week. it's still hard to hang up that connection.

Carrie Gabaree (Gutierrez)

01:06:32
Yeah.

Erica Koelder
01:06:33
Because at the back of our minds, we all know That you never know Yeah what's gonna happen. Because the bad guys are still out there and the bad guys still don't like us. And You know? So you have to kind of let that one hang out back here and not really think about it because it makes phone calls and Skyping and emails just that much more difficult. Yeah

Carrie Gabaree (Gutierrez)
01:06:59
Um in general Or specifically. Um and I you you've kind of addressed this, but I I just want to ask this again in case there's anything you want to add from your experiences as a wife and a um FRSA. How do deployments affect marriages and families? And maybe you want to make this a more overall statement. It's up to you.

Erica Koelder
01:07:25
In general they're either going to make or break your family. And it depends, you know, it starts with army leadership, you know, not just the individual family. You've got to start at your command level.

01:07:39
And you know how important is family to that command group and if they have an emphasis on the family they're gonna help the soldiers spend time with their families prepare their families do the right things There are some leaders in the army that say, not really that important, so we we're gonna keep you in the office and you guys are gonna stare at each other, even though you're gonna see each other for the next twelve months and you're not gonna see your family And then there's all sorts of leadership in between. So as a family, you take your cues from that leadership. And then once you figure out kind of how the leadership is gonna react to the family and family time and family activities and family events, then you as a family decide, okay, what are we gonna do?

01:08:25
How are we gonna make this work? Or You get upset, you start snipping at one another, and you get angry, and you make the time leading up to a deployment. really, really hard on one another and you make it really hard on your kids.

01:08:41
Because at the end of the day, the army family, starting with the husband and wife, and then if you have children, you know, involving them. You ultimately decide whether or not a deployment in the Army life is going to be successful. There are times that you have to work

your butts off to make it successful.

01:09:03
And there's other times that it just kind of comes naturally. But when it comes naturally, that's when everybody has a good army family and everything's right and everything's great. It's the times where it's, you know, the night before your husband's walking out the door and what are you gonna do?

01:09:20
And it's you know, while he's gone, are you going to actively include that soldier in your life? Are you going to make sure to do everything that you need to do? to be a part of his life.

01:09:34
Or are you just gonna say, you know what? It's too hard. They're gone.

01:09:37
I'm gonna you know, I'm not gonna be here when they get back. I don't want to be here when they get back. This isn't what I signed up for.

01:09:45
It's too hard. Mm-hmm. Or This isn't what I signed up for, but I'll figure it out.

01:09:53
Don't really have a choice because this is what my husband wants to do and if I like him, I'll stick with him and we'll we'll figure something out. And You know, for me personally, with me and my husband, we made the choice that we were going to just Tough it out and figure it out because it's temporary. Even though s you know, that are in the army twenty and thirty years, it's temporary You're gonna have a life after the army.

01:10:25
And there's ways that you can have a life outside of the army even while your husband is active duty You just have to figure out what works for you. And what works for you isn't gonna work for the family next door to you, or the family on the other side, or the family across the street. You have to know yourself, you have to know your soldier, and you just have to find a way to make it work.

01:10:46
And I've been very fortunate in my personal life that my soldier wants to find a way to make it work. And we as a family find ways to make things happen and to have a successful army marriage. And we've already seen, you know, just we've only been married a shade over three years and we've seen some of our friends' families fall apart.

01:11:11
As an FRSA, I see families falling apart and Sometimes it really sucks that there's nothing that I

can do about it because I just want to say, you know what, just a little bit longer. You're almost there. It's almost over.

01:11:30
But I don't live in that house. I don't know what else is going on. Right.

01:11:34
And so the army just makes you work differently on your marriage than a civilian marriage. Because civilian marriages, from what I hear, they're pretty tough too. And there's all these you know, there's all sorts of things that go on in the civilian world that don't go on in the army and vice versa.

01:11:56
And so you just you know know if you're gonna if it's gonna work, you're gonna make it work, regardless whether you're in the army or you're in the civilian world. And there are families that are like this army life is too hard. I'm over it.

01:12:08
We're done. We're getting out. They're back out in the civilian war, they're like, okay, maybe it wasn't so bad.

01:12:15
You know, maybe I didn't give it all the credit that it deserved. And then there's some people that are like, no, it it was the best decision for our family to leave and to no longer be a part of it. And so you just you have to have faith in your family and figure out what it is that you're doing and be not just husband and wife or soldier and spouse, like the more you can be a team in the army as a family, the easier it is on your army family and on your army experience to go through the challenges, to go through the deployments.

01:12:56
Especially soldiers that have to go back to back to back. And I can only imagine how trying that is. I haven't had that experience.

01:13:06
I hope I don't. But they have to find their own way and what works for them and I hope that they do. And I hope, you know, when my husband goes back again Because, you know, he was gone and then I sent my soldiers and then we're looking for him to be going pretty soon after I bring my last soldiers home. So for me, it'll be almost like back-to-back-to-back deployments.

01:13:36
And we're gonna struggle with it, and I know that. because we both know this, we're starting to work on it now. All right, let's spend time together.

01:13:47

Let's, you know, instead of sitting at home this weekend, maybe let's go down to the lake and rent the boat and go on a picnic or let's do You know, let's take advantage of some of the activities that the Army has, you know, and maybe go on a weekend retreat to strengthen and our communication and strengthen our marriage, even though you know we're not close to falling apart. But just to have those kind of tools in our toolkit so that when the bad, big, nasty stuff happens Maybe we're a little bit more ready than we're gonna give ourselves credit for. And so it's just knowing, you know, and getting a little bit outside your comfort zone and trying to figure out the best way that you can.

01:14:27
Right.

Carrie Gabaree (Gutierrez)
01:14:27
So what do you um I and I don't know how familiar you are with with this, but what do you think um or how do you think it's different for husbands and wives and families not living on bases um, you know, with m what seems to be more immediately available support, how do you think that they or how how have you heard or experienced that they deal with these same challenges?

Erica Koelder
01:14:52
Um A lot of the families that I have found through my position that are not living close to the installation are home with family. A huge majority of them are home with other family members. Okay.

01:15:07
And that's their coping mechanism. You know, whether they have children or not, or they feel that it's best for them to be closer to family and not be a part of the army while their soldier is gone. And that might be their coping mechanism.

01:15:20
It might be the best thing for them. And then it's my job and the job of the rear detachment element to make sure that if they are not close to the installation and they need something, they're still part of our unit. They're still part of our army family.

01:15:36
So what do we need to do to help them? And, you know Just making sure that everybody, you know, wherever they are, if it's, you know, specifically, you know, they're at Fort Riley or if they're home with mom and dad or you know know, living in a beach house in Florida because they want to, whatever it is. Mm-hmm.

01:15:59

If that's the best decision for them, great. How can we support you and what can we do to make this separation and this deployment as safe and healthy and happy as we can. And so me personally, I can't imagine going home and not being at an installation while my husband is deployed.

01:16:22
I could change my mind. If my husband and I ever have children, I might change my mind and say, oh my gosh, I want a second set of hands to be around if I just need an hour to be by myself. But the army has those resources, you have to know how to find them.

01:16:40
And so I mean it's just it's different for everybody. But me personally, I don't think I would ever do it.

Carrie Gabaree (Gutierrez)
01:16:46
Okay.

Erica Koelder
01:16:47
Because I now that I'm, you know, eyeballs deep in the army, working for them and being married to them. There's times when I almost need the army. And I need the army and I need the structure to kind of be around because that's what my husband's going through.

01:17:04
And by me having that same sort of structure kind of makes me feel like we're doing it together instead of he's just off wherever, I'm off wherever. And that's that's me personally. And that's him and that's a decision that we've actually made as a family is you know until further notice we're sticking it out at that duty station and we're gonna be there.

01:17:26
Okay

Carrie Gabaree (Gutierrez)
01:17:28
What is the divorce rate for um husbands and wives in the Army?

Erica Koelder
01:17:39
It's probably I don't have the exact numbers. I would say it's probably a little bit higher than what the national average divorce rate is. The problem, I guess you would call it, with the divorce rate in the army and the military as a whole, the military as a whole is a really easy group to dissect.

Carrie Gabaree (Gutierrez)

01:18:00
Okay.

Erica Koelder
01:18:01
It's easy to segment us from the civilian population and say, let's examine your divorce rate. Mm-hmm. Let's look at it.

01:18:09
Because we're it's an easy group to pick out. While you're still getting a diverse group of families, you know, number of children in your families, all these other things. It's just like w a civilian life in a little bubble.

Carrie Gabaree (Gutierrez)
01:18:24
Okay.

Erica Koelder
01:18:25
And so the divorces are magni like issues get magnified in a divorce. Um, you know, children and their needs get magnified much differently in a divorce. Um, you know, depending on that soldier's previous tour and how they come home and how they're feeling and how they are coping and handling that stress.

01:18:53
Is gonna affect divorce rates. So, you know, I mean, you can be on a duty station and there's a whole heap of divorces from one unit. And then there's only maybe a couple from another.

01:19:09
But then you go back and sit and say They were in firefights day in and day out and day in and day out. These guys were in a firefight and then they had some time in between. So they were able to kind of call home Then they were maybe in another one.

01:19:25
And so there's so many things that play into divorces that are caused by the army. Mm-hmm. Per se.

01:19:32
Yeah. So it's very situational. It is.

01:19:35
And again, a lot of it depends on what you do and how your relationship is going into a deployment or during a deployment and the choices that you make. as a spouse at home, the choices that your soldier makes while they're deployed and the choices that you make together. So okay.

Carrie Gabaree (Gutierrez)
01:19:59
Another question I think you've you've um I don't know if you've tackled it or already or you've already you've at least touched on it, but I do want to ask it just in case there's anything that you want to add, what have been some of your most successful and challenging moments as an FRSA? And I think you've mentioned a few obvious ones as as a wife. But if if there's anything else that you'd like to add, please feel free.

Erica Koelder
01:20:31
Personally, I feel like one of the most successful things I have done as an FRSA is get involved with my families. I have been at so many family readiness group or FRG meetings, meeting families, talking to them showing the families that I am supporting their FRG volunteer leaders. Getting, you know, just eyeballing families so that if I see them in the commissary or at the PX or driving, you know Hi and they can call me by name and I can call them by name.

01:21:08
You know, and that's across all five of the companies that I support and that includes all my command group and all my staff element And being able to do that, you know, and since my husband's been home, having his blessing to, you know, take time away from our family and be there. For my other six hundred and fifty or six hundred, six hundred and fifty some soldiers and their families. I love it.

01:21:33
And I feel that that's one of the most successful things that I've done because then I'm able to turn around go to my command group and say, hey, this is kind of what's going on. This is the pulse of the unit right now. What do you think if we have this event.

01:21:51
Oh, we never thought about that. Yeah, let's, you know, let's do that. You know, let's have a Christmas party.

01:21:59
at you know a local arcade and the next thing we know we have 200 families there. That's a lot of people for an army function while the soldiers are deployed. You know, and when other FRSAs around Fort Riley heard how big and how successful our Christmas party was, it was a pretty big deal.

01:22:23
You know, and we have other events that we have going on. Just a couple weeks ago, we were able to support bringing 31 families to Great Wolf Lodge in Kansas City and give them the opportunity to be together and to bond and talk about communication techniques while your soldier is deployed. We were able to, you know, put together events like that And knowing my

families the way that I do, I'm able to say, this is what's probably gonna be successful.

01:22:54

This might not be so successful, so let's put our resources into something that is gonna work. You know, and as an my most successful thing as an army wife is that I am still married to the army and I still like being married to the army because there are days that I don't like it But I'm like, all right, whatever, I'll get over it. And you know, a lot of people get married and are divorced very quickly.

01:23:21

And, you know, my husband and I It's not that way. Like I just I absolutely have all faith and confidence that, you know, whatever his army destiny is is gonna become my army destiny and it's gonna become our family's army destiny, whatever duty station, whatever assignment, big, small you know, stressful, not stressful. That's just how it's gonna be and that's what's gonna work and that's what I believe in.

01:23:52

And to be able to believe in that and be okay with it to me is wonderful. Because that means that it's that much less stress that I get to deal with. You know, and just you know, to be able to walk in the door in the morning of my office and say I get to work for the Die Hard Battalion and my job is to support soldiers and their families.

01:24:17

Is such an amazing Amazing opportunity. Never in a million years did I think I was gonna do it, but it's such an amazing gift to be able to do that and to give you know, as my job to give back to soldiers and their families and help them make their lives easier is an amazing slightly mind-boggling thing that sometimes I'm just like I have to pinch myself and say, Oh yeah, this is what's going on. All right, okay.

01:24:48

All right. You know, and then it's even more amazing when I walk in the door of my home and there's my husband with our fat little dog and You know, and that's what I get to come home to. And I get to come home to the two of them and say, All right, this is just that much better.

01:25:09

Like whatever joys and everything I have in my job Nothing can measure to being married to the army and being married to my husband because it's an amazing opportunity to get to be with him and watch him grow in the army. And you know, every time I walk in a door and I take an opportunity and I meet new people and all these other things and I'm like, man, this just keeps getting better. Are you kidding me?

01:25:41

And it's an amazing feeling.

Carrie Gabaree (Gutierrez)
01:25:44
So in in your job as an FRSA, um how how demanding is it? I mean how many do you there are are I imagine kind of the flow it differs Um, but I imagine there are maybe some times when you have tons of requests piling through the door and you have to prioritize them and how do you deal with that? How do you juggle with how do you juggle that

Erica Koelder
01:26:08
Um, I wish I would have brought a picture for you. I have a gigantic whiteboard in my office that I have taped off. by project what needs to get done.

01:26:20
If it's not on my whiteboard, it's not getting done. I'm a very visual person. I like to see what's going on.

01:26:26
I like to see my calendars. I like people to, you know, kind of keep me in the loop so that I can be planning and organizing and executing different events and different things. And Because the engineer branch is unique to the Army in that they don't necessarily deploy as a full brigade level element They can deploy as a battalion, they can deploy down to the company level.

01:26:56
So when you have, you know, the potential for multiple deployment cycles. There's never a dull moment in my job. Okay.

01:27:07
As of right now, I have three deployment cycles that I am working on. And in the next six months I will be bringing soldiers home at three different times. Which is, you know, without my whiteboard in front of me to keep me calm is slightly overwhelming because that's a lot of coordination And a lot of you know making sure that everybody is taking care of what they need to and that we're taking care as a rear detachment element of what we need to and you know, making sure that our volunteers, you know, are helping their families, but they have to get ready to bring their husband home too.

01:27:52
So it's making sure that we're taking care of them and doing all these different things and with my job specifically to the Die Hard Battalion there is never ever a dull moment. They keep me on my toes probably more than they should. So But I love it.

01:28:09
I love that chaos and that craziness that goes into it because I know what the end state is. I know that the end state is bringing home soldiers and reuniting them with their families. So the chaos and the noise and everything going on over here, great.

01:28:27
So be it. It's gonna be that way for a while. Because that's what I'm gonna do.

01:28:32
is I know on three different days I'm gonna get to see my soldiers with their families again. And that's what gets me through the chaos and the noise of my day. is because that's what's gonna happen and I am excited.

Carrie Gabaree (Gutierrez)
01:28:51
From all of your experiences with the army Uh you know, being an army wife, is there anything so far? Hindsight's always twenty twenty. Is there anything that you would change if you were if you could go back and and do that? Gosh.

Erica Koelder
01:29:10
I don't think so, okay. Just Again, I'm a huge proponent proponent of army destiny. Like whatever happens with the army, whatever big army says It's for a reason.

01:29:26
We might not know it at the time. But for whatever reason, we are meant to be in that place at that time in that assignment with those people for P that period of time. And I look back, you know, at the experiences and again I've only been married to the army about three and a half years and I'm like But we've gotten to do some really neat things and meet really neat people and who knows how meeting them and being with them is going to affect our army future.

01:30:00
You know what's going on right now with me and my husband. We don't know how that's gonna affect our army future. We make the best decisions that we can and once you make 'em, you're not changing 'em.

01:30:12
You can't I mean, if it was turns out to be the wrong decision, whatever however it was the wrong decision, something will come out of it. Another assignment, another army family that you can be with and be a part of, you know, another duty station, another job for me. Something, whatever it is, and again, we don't always know.

01:30:38
Because when my husband got to Fort Riley and then walked out the door, I was devastated. Now after having the opportunity to work for the die-hards and meet the people that I have and be a part of what I've been able to, I wouldn't trade this experience for the world. I love it.

01:30:56
I love being able to, you know, have the opportunity to have the job that I have and be working

for who I get to and then meeting with my husband's soldiers and my husband's famil you know, my husband's families and we would never have met them otherwise.

Speaker 4
01:31:10
Mm-hmm.

Erica Koelder
01:31:10
You know, and if he was supposed to end up at another unit at Fort Riley like we had originally thought, who knows what would have happened. I might not have ended up working for the Die Hard Battalion. We might not have met, you know, the great friends that we have.

01:31:26
We might you know something as simple as we might not have lived in the quarters that we do. You know, I mean just silly things like that. And so it's too hard and sometimes too stressful to look back and say, oh, we should have done this differently, we should have done that differently.

01:31:44
'cause at the end of the day it's not changing. Yeah. And all you can do is just move forward with the opportunities that the army presents you and do the best that you can.

01:31:53
Right. If you do anything else I people do and that's their choice. I don't have the time.

01:32:01
Yeah. It's and not only that I don't have the capacity to sit back and play the what if game, it's too mentally tough to do that.

Carrie Gabaree (Gutierrez)
01:32:11
So okay. On a scale of one to ten, and from what you've said, it I think it kind of maybe varies on, you know, what person you're talking to in the army, but on a scale of one to ten, how supportive do you feel that the army is of wives, husbands, and families?

Erica Koelder
01:32:31
I can only speak to me personally with me and my husband. And we have found the army to be probably in the eight, nine, ten range. Okay.

01:32:41
I work for families that would completely disagree with me and they would call me a bold-faced liar and they would say like the army has been like one, two, three supportive of me. And that's all based on your circumstances and your experiences and the choices that you as a person

make. And how you choose to use what resources are available to you in the army.

01:33:08
And The people that are gonna say, you know, the army has been completely unsupportive of me, you know, and hang out in the one, two, three end of the scale. are usually the families that choose not to get involved and choose not to use the resources that are available to them and choose to complain and try to make everybody else's life miserable. Because there are pe um but in the same breath, there are people like that that aren't in the army.

01:33:35
Like if you're just living out, you know, normal wherever you're living. There are plenty of people like that. You know, and then there's people, you know, kind of on me and my husband's end that say, yes, the army has been extremely supportive of us.

01:33:49
But my husband and I are involved in a lot of things and we you know, we are involved with other families, we're involved with other activities. In my opinion, we make positive choices. When it comes to the army, we do at the end of the day I think we do the right thing.

01:34:08
Not that the people that say the army is completely unsupportive that they're doing the wrong thing. That's the right thing for them. That's just not the right thing for me and my husband.

01:34:19
So but yeah, there are plenty of people that would say nope, the army hasn't done anything for me. The army is completely unsupportive, they hate families, they are not, you know, they're not anything like they say they are. And then there's people in the middle and then there's, you know, I mean there's you're gonna hit everybody across the board.

01:34:42
Okay. But I can only truthfully speak to me and my husband personally, and that's the eight, nine, ten end of the scale for sure

Carrie Gabaree (Gutierrez)
01:34:48
Okay. In your job as obviously you're not really, you know, you're not a counselor, you're not a therapist, but I so I guess the appropriate situation to ask about here is um, you know, an example would be there's a new military wife. Um, coming to Fort Riley with her husband. Um, as you've been doing this for a while now, when meeting someone like that um who's new to the lifestyle and the culture, what do you tell her?

Erica Koelder
01:35:18
Oh gosh, I don't think you have enough tape left. Um with my job and with my personality I've

been fortunate enough that I'm kind of able to gauge how people want to be approached because you can dive in and you know be up to your eyeballs and For you that might work. And for other people they might just need to dip a little toe in.

01:35:46
And so you have to really, really, you know, work with them and ask them, you know, what can What questions do you have? And if they say, Oh, I don't have any, you're like, okay. When you do have questions Here is who you need to get a hold of.

01:36:06
And it's just making sure that somebody kind of talks to them and asks them at various stages. of, you know, getting acclimated to the army? What you know, would going out and going to a picnic with a bunch of other ladies, you know, for a social event, was that something that you would want to do?

01:36:29
Or would you rather just kinda meet one lady here and one lady there and not necessarily go to big chaotic events. you know, and figuring out because no matter what, like if I meet somebody who really just wants to dip a little toe in, mm-hmm. I am not going to be the best person for her to meet because I'm all about just jumping in and figuring it out.

01:36:56
And so I have to know what my abilities are as an army wife and an FRSA to help that wife be successful and know that not everybody is like me and not everybody wants to get involved and go to all these different things and meet everybody and you know, do all these different things 'cause not everybody is that way. And sometimes I have a hard time remembering that 'cause I think everybody should wanna, you know, go out to the barbecues and go out to the picnics and go to the ball games and just be together and you know, just general chaos. And sometimes it's very hard for me to remember that.

01:37:34
You know, but just making sure that you know, hey, I've been where you are. It's okay if you don't have the answers. It's okay if you feel lost.

01:37:44
Once you figure out how you want to go about things and how your family wants to go about things. Let me know what I can do to help.

Carrie Gabaree (Gutierrez)
01:37:52
Okay.

Erica Koelder
01:37:53

Because at the end of the day, we as Army families and Army wives, we do need each other. Regardless of whether or not we like it, we do need each other. And I might need somebody you know, just to be a resource for me, or I might need somebody to be my friend, or I might need someone heavens, I might need someone to watch my dog for a couple hours, you know, I mean and you find the army friends and the army wives that you need to surround yourself.

01:38:26
And no matter what I do and no matter what these other army wives do We all individually make our own decisions and we find our own way. And you just have to decide how many people are gonna go along with you on your army wife journey, for lack of better term terms to figure it out. I have a whole gaggle of women behind me.

01:38:47
And that's just my personality. And I the more the merrier. And I use those women.

01:38:53
all the time for all different sorts of things. You know, I will call, I have to go to this event, this is what the dress c the dress code is, what am I gonna wear? Yeah.

01:39:04
You know, something as seemingly silly as that, or oh my gosh, I have a family that's going through this, this, this, and this, and I am even at a loss. as to what to do. You know, and for me, having that whole gaggle of women behind me supporting me helps me then turn around and help my families.

01:39:25
So

Carrie Gabaree (Gutierrez)
01:39:28
To for for women or husbands I suppose, but pr maybe particularly wives out there who um you know they're civilian and um Um for people who really don't understand anything about being an army wife, do you have a message for them? Is there something that um Um, you know, if they were to ask about it, is there something in particular that you would like to tell them that maybe they you think they should know?

Erica Koelder
01:39:58
Just be patient with us. You know, if we you know, 'cause especially when our husbands are gone, we are a very, very special group of people, special group of ladies while our husbands are gone because we're upset. And we're tired and we're stressed out and we're a lot of things.

01:40:15
A lot more so I think than our civilian counterparts maybe can understand. And and know, just

but we're not, you know, I don't know, we're not crazy, we're not freaks. I mean we're just like regular wives.

01:40:34
We love our husbands. They have a job to do. They're just on a really long business trip.

Carrie Gabaree (Gutierrez)
01:40:39
Yeah.

Erica Koelder
01:40:40
You know, and when The easiest way to make an army wife upset is, oh my gosh, my husband's on a week and a half long business trip. I don't know how I'm gonna get through the week and a half without him. Are you kidding me?

01:40:55
Yeah you know, understand that we might not always be the most understanding in situations because we have such a different perspective and we have such a different take on separation and family and family time. But that, you know At the end of the day, we have such a unique story that if you have the opportunity It's kind of nice to have one of us in your back pocket hanging out because it is something that not everybody gets to experience or be a part of. And so having an army wife, you know, around you that you, you know, have confidence in and that you trust and are friends with, to be able to, you know, ask questions.

01:41:43
Because there's a lot of people I have found That do support soldiers and want to support their families and they don't know how. Great, I'll tell you how. You know, and so you know, finding ways to support her, especially while her husband is gone.

01:42:00
If it's you know, just the little things that having that you that civilians take for granted by having a husband and wife around you know understand that not everybody has that luxury and you know trying to stop a foot and a you know taking a step in her shoes and understanding and being there for her.

Carrie Gabaree (Gutierrez)
01:42:21
Mm-hmm. So okay. Erica, that's all of the questions that I have for you. But I do want to say um is there anything that I didn't ask that you feel that I should have, or is there anything that you would like to add?

Erica Koelder
01:42:40

No, but I will tell you one other thing. Sure. I don't you'll have seen on here I wanted to make sure that I represented both the battalion that I work for as well as my husband's squadron, and you'll also find that a lot of army wives will wear the crests that belong to their husband and since I have both of them, you know, I get the pleasure and privilege of wearing both of them.

01:43:01
And this is for the First Engineer Battalion um currently commanded by Lieutenant Colonel Bob Whittle and Command Sergeant Major James Benton. And then this is for my husband's unit, which is 5-4 Cavalry, 2nd Heavy Brigade, 1st Infantry Division, Fort Riley, Kansas. So I'm pretty proud of them and being able to be a part of both of those organizations has been such an amazing opportunity.

01:43:26
And You know, as people go through and as they see this, you know, these aren't gonna change. These have been around since the inception of these units as part of their history and you know, being here, this is gonna become part of their history and, you know, years to come, there's still gonna be wives in the first engineer battalion that are gonna hear always first, die hard uh and they're gonna have this on and they're gonna be like oh they did that too all right you know and same thing with my husband you know with my husband's unit they're always gonna be the cavalry and that's you know Cavalry, even as it goes through its changes, they're always gonna be the cavalry and they're always gonna have their states and they're always gonna have their spurs and they're always gonna have their sabers and be so pro Out of them You know, and so I mean, a hundred years from now, someone will be probably sitting in the same position wearing one or both of these, and she'll be like, Oh, but so I'm not the only one. Erica, thank you so much for the Torah history.

Carrie Gabaree (Gutierrez)
01:44:29
Really appreciate it. Thank you. He says it's the story of my life.

01:44:38
That's fun. Can we go downstairs? Oh no, you're still doing the center, sorry.

01:44:42
Yeah, still secondary.

Speaker 4
01:44:45
Yes, I have had to wear those because it's not like I belonged one, I have two